

What's wrong with chatgpt "using water". Isn't water infinite?

Posted by u/360_bratXcX • 0 points • 6 comments

people complain that generative ai uses so much water to generate prompts, responses, and images. but isn't water renewable? how is AI a problem to the environment?

Comments

u/Open-Celebration1380 • 1 points • 2025-06-21 00:42 UTC

treating the water to reuse costs money. So take for example Memphis which has a lot of poverty. Musk is setting up huge AI facility there to get water and cheap energy (TVA) but! this will likely cause huge pollution and drive up the cost of water for poor people. He doesnt care that's why he chose it. They're even lying about how much pollution they're causing and it's only been a few months.

u/archpawn • 1 points • 2025-06-21 00:41 UTC

Rivers only bring in water at a limited rate, and we have a limited amount of well water to draw on to supplement that. ChatGPT isn't significant compared to how much agriculture uses, but most people aren't used to that, so the numbers sound big. Combine that with all the AI hate, and you get people repeating it thinking it's a big deal.

u/lowflier84 • 2 points • 2025-06-21 00:39 UTC

Not all water on Earth is equal. Over 97% is salt water in the ocean. Of the roughly 3% that is fresh water, most of that is locked away in polar ice or underground. Only about 1% of freshwater, or .03% of all water on Earth, is readily available in lakes and rivers.

u/MrLongJeans • 3 points • 2025-06-21 00:36 UTC

Water requires energy to do things with. It doesn't appear without plumbing, drainage, and processing/collection/storage.

A.I. uses a lot of electricity which is a larger challenge

u/DONT_PM_ME_DICKS • 5 points • 2025-06-21 00:36 UTC

drinkable fresh water is effectively a limited resource, in the sense that nature only provides so much at any given time, and processing waste water back to reasonably pure water is very energy intensive.

there are also concerns about the effects of dumping large amounts of heat into local water sources, and how that could impact the ecosystem of those bodies of water.

u/Free_PalletLine • 2 points • 2025-06-21 00:36 UTC

Clean fresh water is not a finite resource, it's renewable but consumes a lot of energy and puts stress on local infrastructure and environments.